BUILDER, STEP 12

What an agent is.

Four parts. One page.

A goal, tools, a loop and a stop rule. With a free brief to fill in.

DURING COVID

Goro, a fishing village in Italy. About 30 hours of driving, there and back. Twice a week.



The driving, the selling, the logistics, and finding customers in Germany, the Netherlands and Belgium.

The first trip went wrong. Part of the fish could not be sold, so we gave a lot of it away.

That job had a goal, tools and a loop. An agent has one more part.

THE FOUR PARTS

An agent has four parts.

→ **Goal:** what must be true at the end

→ **Tools:** what it may use

→ **Loop:** act, look at the result, adjust

→ **Stop rule:** when it stops, or stops and asks you

> Agents are "typically just LLMs using tools based on environmental feedback in a loop."

Anthropic, Building effective agents

NOT AN AGENT

A chat answer answers once.

CHAT ANSWER	AGENT
Answers your question	Works toward a goal
You decide the next step	Decides its own next step
You check the result	Checks its own result, then adjusts
Stops after one answer	Stops by a rule, or stops and asks

Not every job needs an agent. But every agent needs all four parts.

YESTERDAY'S STEP

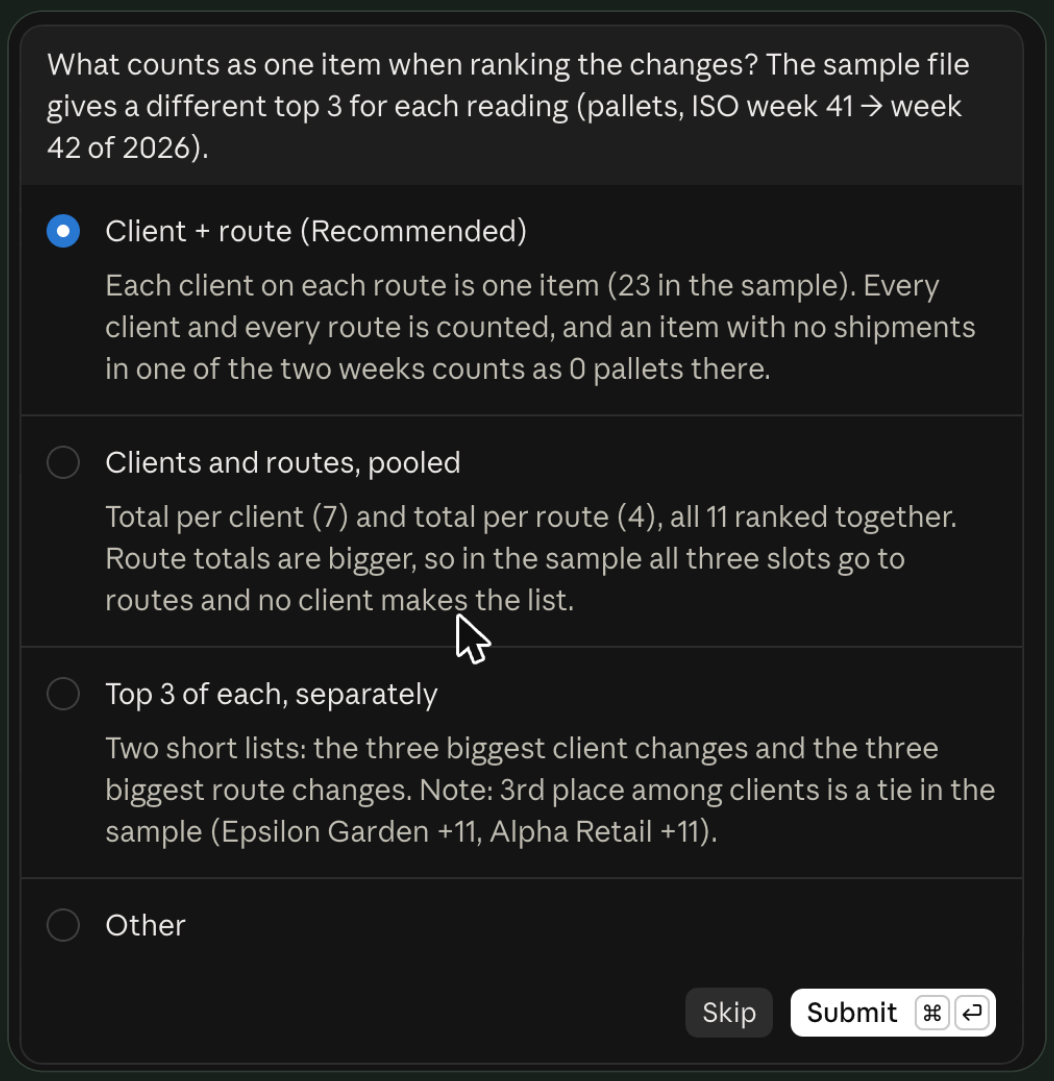
Step 11 was an agent.

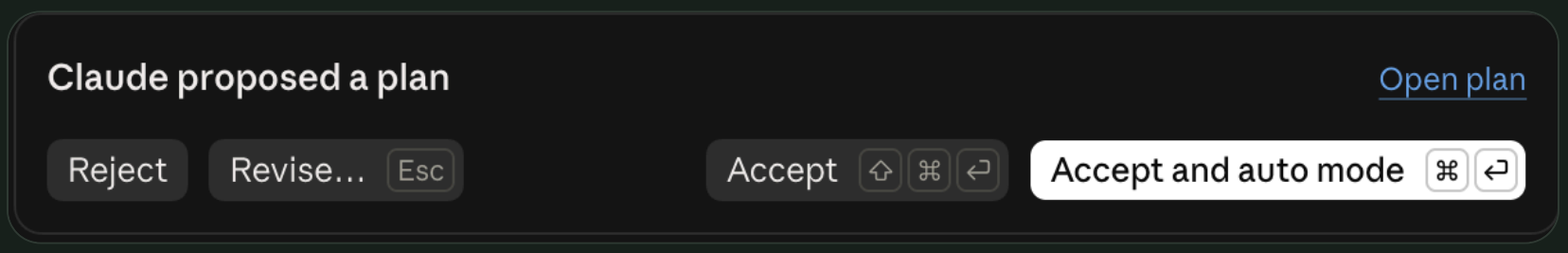
Goal	A script that prints the three biggest changes, and a README with the rule
Tools	The sample export, Python, its own branch
Loop	It wrote the script, ran it, and tested two edge cases on its own
Stop rule	Plan mode: it showed its plan and waited

The stop rule did one more thing. Next slide.

THE STOP RULE

When it did not know, it stopped and asked.





And before any change, it showed its plan and waited for us.

THE PART MOST PEOPLE SKIP

A stop rule is a check, not a wish.

NOT A STOP RULE	A STOP RULE
"Make it better"	"Run it once on the sample file and show me the output"
"Ask me if unsure"	"Ask me when the rule for one item is unclear"
(nothing)	"Done when the output matches expected-output.md"

Without one, an agent keeps going, or it guesses.

FREE FILES

Write a brief for one job.

- → The agent brief: goal, tools, loop, stop rule, and what it may never do
- → The step 11 job as a filled-in brief
- → Our test: Claude Code showed its plan, asked one question, then printed the expected three lines

On my profile under Featured: AI Starter Kit, step 12.

Tomorrow: Claude Code on your own laptop, in one line.